

Amphibious warfare
Amphibious landing techniques are a mainstay of Marine Corps training. Here a company disembarks from an M-113 Armoured Personnel Carrier on the coast of South Vietnam, 1965.



Canteen
This standard-issue canteen, still in use today, holds 95ml (1 US quart) of water.

By 1968 just over one in ten Marines were black, although a significantly higher percentage would be found at the sharp end of the war, with less in safe technical or administrative jobs. Black officers were rare – less than one in a hundred in 1968. White or black, the grunts tended to belong to the less educated, most underprivileged strata of American society. They would make courageous soldiers, but not necessarily sensitive ambassadors for the American way of life.

INTO VIETNAM

The Marines were deployed in the northern sector of South Vietnam, in a region abutting the Demilitarized Zone (DMZ) that separated the US-backed South from communist-ruled North Vietnam. The area in which they had to operate comprised a densely populated coastal plain and, further inland, the wild jungle-clad mountains of the Annamese Cordillera.

Both the plain and the mountains were challenging, alien environments for the Marine soldier. Amid the villages and rice-paddies of the plain he was surrounded by a population with a culture and language he did not understand, and in which active supporters of the Viet Cong guerrillas were indistinguishable from genuine noncombatants. In the Highlands he had to seek out an elusive enemy among jagged ridges and ravines wreathed in mist, cutting a path through the tangled vines of triple-canopy forest with a machete, plagued by insects and battling with heat and humidity. Even on routine patrols in areas theoretically under the control of the South Vietnamese government, there was a steady drain of casualties from mines and booby traps (which the Viet Cong excelled at making), or sniper fire.

Once away from an American base, no soldier could afford to relax – taking off your flak jacket because you were hot could cost you your life.

At first the Marines faced the challenge of Vietnam with good morale and adapted well to the difficult conditions. They even mounted an intelligent counter-insurgency effort in the villages known as the Combined Action Program. This involved putting small squads of Marines in "friendly" hamlets alongside local militia to keep out the Viet Cong. It was one of the few occasions when the American military chose to regard ordinary Vietnamese as potential friends and allies. But little of the Marines' time was devoted to winning hearts and minds. Their main function was to seek out and destroy the enemy, whether Viet Cong guerrillas or NVA soldiers, primarily in the thinly populated Highlands. US commanders believed that they could win the conflict through a combination of the mobility provided by helicopters and maximum use of the firepower available to American forces. To provide the firepower, Marines set up firebases in advanced positions from which their artillery could then support infantry advancing into enemy-controlled territory. Helicopters inserted Recon teams of six to eight Marines into hostile territory to track the movements of enemy formations, or ferried larger units into jungle landing zones (LZs) from which they could launch patrols in search of the enemy.

It proved an exhausting and costly way of waging war. Men advancing through forested mountains carrying 36kg (80lb) of kit – including an M16 rifle, grenades, ammunition, canteens, entrenching tool, machete, first-aid kit, and flak

M79 "Blooper"
With a maximum range of 300m (984ft), the M79 grenade launcher fills the gap between the hand grenade and the mortar. Two were issued to each rifle squad.

